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Witchcraft, oracles and magic among the Azande

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Document Type: Book

Original Page: 376

Culture (OWC): [Azande \(F007\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Central Africa

Field Date: 1926-1930

Coverage Date: Late 1800s-1930

Place Coverage: Zande District, Sudan

Section Title(S): X

(5) The *makama* consists of a cone of wood and a conical sheath, also of wood. According as the cone is thrust into the sheath it is easy or almost impossible to pull it out. Witch-doctors hand it to members of their audience at seances to discover whether they are witches (see p. 165). They hold the sheath and present the cone to the people they want to test. Those who fail to pull out the cone are suspected of witchcraft though the test is regarded lightly by every one and rather in the nature of a joke.

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Many Azande are aware that whether or not a man can pull the cone out depends on the way in which it was put in by a witch-doctor. An informant said:

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'This is the custom of *makama*: if they twist it forcibly it sticks; if they twist it gently it does not stick. They twist it forcibly to hand it to a man, and he and the witch-doctor tug at it together. Meanwhile the witch-doctor silently addresses the *makama*: "If this man is a witch let the *makama* remain tight when he pulls it." They both tug at it. If the man is not a witch they pull the two pieces of wood apart.

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'The witch-doctor twists the cone into the sheath and hands it to another man and silently addresses it thus: "If this man is a witch and has come to spoil divination let *makama* remain tight when he pulls it. If he is a witch let the *makama* remain tight when he pulls it." The man and the witch-doctor tug at the *makama* and they continue tugging, and every

one says, " Yöl the witch-doctor has caught him with the *makama*, he is a witch." Such is the custom of the *makama*.'

(6) Major Larken writes of an ordeal by boiling water. If a person who submits to it shows no trace of scald he is proved innocent.¹ Hutereau records the same custom among the Zande-speaking Adio.² As far as I am aware it is only practised in Gbudwe's kingdom by foreign peoples conquered by the Azande.

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(7) Azande say that the kind of hut which is built with mud walls unsupported by stakes acts as an omen. These huts are the most difficult kind to build and the walls sometimes collapse. This is a bad omen for the welfare of its owner, especially if it be the first hut to be built in a new homestead, for they say, 'The first hut in a homestead site tells people about the future.'

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¹ *An Account of the Zande*, op. cit., p. 52.

² Op. cit., pp. 53-4.

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